Adaptability questions

Design Gurus

Here are a few behavioral questions related to leadership and taking initiative:

Question 1: Tell me about a time when you took the initiative to improve a process or implement a new idea within your team.

Intention of the question: The interviewer wants to know whether you improve things nobody asked you to improve. They are also checking whether the change survived after you stopped pushing it.

Pitfalls to avoid: Avoid an idea that was assigned to you, because that is not initiative. Do not describe a change that was adopted and then quietly dropped. If it did not last, say so and say why.

Sample Answer 1:

Situation: "Our team of six spent about a day a week on release. One person ran a checklist of 34 manual steps. The release usually happened on Thursday, because nobody wanted to run it on a Friday."

Task: "Nobody had asked me to fix this. It was accepted as the cost of shipping. What convinced me it was worth doing was that two of our last five incidents came from a missed step on that checklist."

Action: "I did not propose automating all 34 steps, because that is a project and it would have been refused. I picked the three steps behind those two incidents and automated only those. That took about a day and a half of my own time. Then I brought the incident numbers rather than the idea. I asked for one day a sprint to continue, and I got it, because the incidents made the case. Over the next two months we automated 28 of the 34. I deliberately left the six that needed a human decision alone, and made the script stop and ask."

Result: "Release went from about a day to about 40 minutes. We moved to shipping twice a week, then daily. No incident since has come from a missed step. The part I would repeat is starting with a day and a half of unasked work on the smallest piece. Asking permission to automate 34 steps would have been refused. Showing three of them working made the rest easy to agree to."

Sample Answer 2: "A different attempt failed, and it is worth knowing why. I started a weekly design review, because I thought our design quality was uneven. Six people came for three weeks, then attendance fell to two. I had added a meeting without removing anything, and I had never defined what came out of it. When I stopped organizing it, it stopped. A process change only survives if somebody's week gets easier. The release automation lasted because it gave a person their day back. The design review lasted three weeks because it cost everyone an hour and produced nothing they could point at."

Follow-up you should expect: "You spent a day and a half of your own time before asking. How do you decide that is worth doing?"

Why they ask: They want to know whether this is a habit with judgment behind it, or whether you routinely work on things nobody sanctioned.

How to answer it: "I set a limit before I start, usually a day or two. I only spend it when I have evidence rather than an opinion. Here the evidence was two incidents from one checklist. If a day and a half is not enough to show something working, the idea is too big to start this way. I write it up instead. I have abandoned two of these at the limit. Both times the work turned out to be larger than it looked, which was worth finding out in a day rather than a month."

Question 2: Tell me about a time when you mentored or helped train a junior team member. What was your approach, and what did you learn from the experience?

Intention of the question: The interviewer wants to see whether you can make somebody else better. They are also checking whether you know the difference between helping a person and doing the work for them.

Pitfalls to avoid: Avoid describing yourself as generous with your time. Do not tell the story only from your side. Say what the person could do afterwards that they could not do before.

Sample Answer 1:

Situation: "A graduate engineer joined my team and was given our payments service to learn. Three weeks in, she was opening about two pull requests a week and each needed several rounds of review. She had started apologizing in her messages, which was the signal I noticed first."

Task: "I was her mentor. The obvious help was to review her code faster and more kindly. I thought the real problem was different. She was working on tasks spread across the service, so she never learned any part of it well enough to stop guessing."

Action: "I stopped answering her questions with answers. When she asked where something happened, I asked how she would find out, then sat with her while she did it. That was slower for about two weeks. I also changed the work she was given. Instead of small changes across the whole service, she got one area: the refund path. She owned everything in it for a month, including the on-call questions. Narrow and deep rather than broad and shallow. We paired for an hour on Tuesdays, which she scheduled, so it was not me deciding when she needed help."

Result: "By the end of that month she was answering other people's questions about refunds, including mine. Her review rounds went from about four to one. She has since led the redesign of that path. What I learned is that my instinct to answer quickly was the thing slowing her down. Answering is faster for me and teaches nothing, and I only noticed because she kept asking the same shape of question."

Sample Answer 2: "I mentored a second engineer badly, and the contrast is what taught me. He was struggling, so I reviewed his code more thoroughly, sometimes leaving 30 comments. He fixed all 30 every time and learned nothing, because I was doing the thinking for him. After two months his work had not improved. I switched to leaving three comments and naming the pattern behind them. His pull requests got worse for two weeks, then better than before. Thirty comments is a rewrite with extra steps. It feels like help while it prevents any."

Follow-up you should expect: "How did you know she was ready to be left alone?"

Why they ask: A mentor who never withdraws creates a dependency. They want to know whether you planned an ending.

How to answer it: "I watched the direction of the questions. In the first weeks she asked me what to do. By week four she was telling me what she planned to do and asking whether it was reasonable. That flip is the signal I use. I also stopped going to her design discussions before I felt comfortable doing it, because staying would have made me the person everyone asked. The Tuesday hour ran for another two months, but she cancelled about half of them, which was the real answer."